

# DOWNTOWN

Sunday  
April 19, 2026

THE HINDU

**T. NAGAR**

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## ‘Service lane under Porur flyover battered’



**S. N. RAJARAM**

The service lane under MGR flyover at Porur junction (where traffic moves towards Guindy) on Mount Poonamallee High Road is battered. Further, a line of share autorickshaws and other vehicles are parked along the lane forcing pedestrians to walk in the middle of

the thoroughfare. It may be noted this lane witnesses good vehicular traffic including MTC buses.

This situation has been persisting for the past few months.

Repeated complaints to the Greater Chennai Corporation were to no avail.

*S. N. Rajaram is a resident of Saligramam*



The service lane under the Porur flyover. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



### Run for ethical voting

Voters Association of India, in association with Election Commission of India, is organising a ‘Mega Marathon’ on April 19 at 5 a.m. to create awareness on ‘Ethical Voting and 100% Voting’.

The event is open to all and the online link requires one to sign a declaration that no political party's flag, shirt, badge or any item that resembles any party will be used during the run.

In case you have not signed up for the run starting at Napier Bridge then show your support on ‘register to pledge’. Visit <https://votersassociation.com/megamarathon/index.php>

## ‘Lakshmi Nagar junction poorly regulated’



Lakshmi Nagar junction on Mount-Poonamallee Road.

**R. KALIDURAI**

The Lakshmi Nagar junction on Mount Poonamallee Road needs better regulation; to be precise, the section of Mount Road between CMRL pillars: 168 and 169. Here, vehicles coming from Lakshmi Nagar

First Main Road try to cross the two-way Mount Poonamallee Road, a State Highway that witnesses heavy traffic. Despite the presence of traffic signals, this spot is chaotic. Further, safety rules are flouted by motorists driving on the wrong direction of the road giving room

for close calls. Pedestrians are also at peril. There is some order when traffic police regulate the junction but they are not deployed on all days. I suggest a U-turn be created near the junction to resolve this issue.

*R. Kalidurai is a resident of Valasaravakkam*

### You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to [downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in](mailto:downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in). Letters must carry the contact number.



## ‘Pedestrians in peril’



Traffic near Duraisamy Road junction in T. Nagar.  
FILE PHOTO

Pedestrians find it difficult to cross the junction of Duraisamy Road and South Usmaan Road in T. Nagar.

To be precise, near Pothys shop. Though it is a short stretch it is

quite unsafe due to continuous flow of vehicles on both sides of the road. The traffic police should look into this issue.

*A. S. Thirumalai is a resident of West Mambalam*



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## 'Panchayat governance does not help Iyyappanthangal'

P. SENTHIL KUMAR

Iyyappanthangal, a Village Panchayat with multi-storey apartments and commercial establishments is replete with issues one would readily identify with an urban area. But it is being governed with the administrative tools meant for rural Panchayats, which makes things hugely ineffective. Residents Welfare Associations believe the solution lies in merging Iyyappanthangal Village Panchayat, located in Alandur Constituency with Greater Chennai Corporation.

One of the primary demands of the Iyyappanthangal Residents Welfare Association is the provision of an underground sewage drainage system. Generally, rural areas are not equipped with such infrastructure. This is probably the reason why Iyyappanthangal lacks this facility. However, the area is highly urbanised and has a sizeable population justifying the provision of an infrastructure for sewage disposal.

A survey was conducted a decade ago to provide this facility, but no progress has been made since. Residents have been raising the issue at Grama Sabha meetings re-



Garbage piles at Mettu Salai in Iyyappanthangal. FILE PHOTO

peatedly. In the absence of an underground sewer system, residents are forced to spend towards clearance of septic tanks. Another key demand is supply of piped drinking water. As a Village Panchayat, Iyyappanthangal falls under the Jal Jeevan Mission, a scheme designed for rural households. As per the scheme, piped water is supplied to individual households. However, this scheme is not suitable for Iyyappanthangal, given the large number of multi-storey apartments in the area. Typically, only one water connection is provided per apartment complex, which is insufficient to meet the needs of residents. This leads to a mismatch between demand and supply.

The association has also raised concerns regarding

solid waste management. There is an urgent need for a dedicated waste recycling yard. Large quantities of waste are generated daily in the Panchayat, but in the absence of proper facilities, waste is often dumped on public roads or disposed of by burning.

Finally, the association has highlighted the need to reclaim decades-old natural water channels that have been encroached upon. As Iyyappanthangal is prone to flooding, restoring these water channels is essential for effective flood management. Restoration of those natural channels will obviate the need for construction of stormwater drains.

P. Senthil Kumar is the coordinator of Confederation of Iyyappanthangal Residents Welfare Associations

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# When a **stool** makes a huge difference at the polling booth



ILLUSTRATION:  
SEBASTIAN FRANCIS

Members of Tamil Nadu Dwarfism Association have reiterated a set of demands, one they always make when it is time to head to the hustings

LIFFY THOMAS

**E**very election, when Dayanand walks into the polling booth at Ranipet in Vellore, he has a prayer on his lips. He needs a prop to be able to vote comfortably and correctly. He needs a stool. Standing just two feet tall, the 28-year-old struggles to press the right button on the electronic voting machine when there is no stool for him to stand on.

Dayanand has been contemplating seeking the 'vote from home' option.

A stool at the polling booth is a unique need faced by those with dwarfism, one of the 21 disabilities in the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016.

Every election, they make this need felt ahead of the visit to the hustings.

At three-and-a-half feet, M.G. Rakul is at a slight advantage. "But I strain to get hold of the right button I want to press," says the Ekkaduthangal resident. Many a time, he has pressed the button on the bottom of the EVM list where his fingers would reach first, unwittingly voting for a political party whose position he does not endorse.

Most people with dwarfism hate to be carried and such experiences at the polling booth leave them with an unpleasant feeling.

In the recently concluded Assembly elections in Kerala, there are reports about a dwarf voter in Thiruvananthapuram who brought his personal stool so that he can vote at ease.

## Assistance at booth

Tamil Nadu Dwarfism Association has made two other requests to the Election Commission. They want a separate line for persons with disabilities at polling stations and volunteers to assist them till the end when the distance from the drop-off point and polling booth is far.

In the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, R. Gopinath's wife, who was recovering from a surgery, found it a herculean task to walk from the drop-off point to the booth.

"The booth in Manali where we voted had wheelchairs and ramps but none to help those who need assistance from the drop-off point," says Gopinath, who heads the Tamil Nadu Dwarfism Association.

In the parliamentary elections, Greater Chennai Corporation had chosen 21 persons to represent different groups of the differently-abled to ensure polling booths were disabled-friendly, but this time none from the dwarfism community was invited.

Despite their request not being met, the community is clear they want to vote and will nudge all others with a valid voting identity card to participate in the process. "There are more than 500 people with dwarfism in Tamil Nadu, and at least 100 in Chennai," says Gopinath.

The Association has sent reminders to all members to exercise their vote. Says Rakul: "This time, we are even asking our members to use the Saksham App and request for a volunteer in advance at the polling booth, but downloading the app and making a request is not easy for many of us."



### For a copy of Voter ID

If your name is on the electoral roll and your mobile number is registered with the Election Commission of India and linked to your EPIC, you can download a copy of your voter ID online from <https://voters.eci.gov.in>

### For quick assistance

Voter helpline numbers

**1950/ 1800 425 0424**

Official website

**[www.elections.tn.gov.in](http://www.elections.tn.gov.in)**

### What to take to the booth

\* Obviously, the Voter Identification Card

\* If you are on the electoral roll, your number registered with ECI, but do not have the Voter ID Card at present, it would help to carry any of these documents with you: Aadhaar Card, PAN card, Indian Passport, Driving Licence or Pension Documents

## Need support on *election day?*

### Inclusive vehicle to take voters to polling booth



**V**idya Sagar, an NGO working for persons with disabilities, has procured an additional vehicle as part of its 'Get Going' initiative that helps those with disabilities travel comfortably in an inclusive vehicle. As in previous years, two of these vehicles will be pressed into service for senior citizens and PwDs wanting to reach the polling booth without any hassle.

The vehicle is equipped with a hydraulic lift and can accommodate up to three wheelchairs with four addi-

tional seats. There are specially trained support staff to meet the needs of the special-needs people.

The NGO charges a fee based on distance between the home and polling booth for ferrying

the voter. During other times of the year, these vehicles are used to take students on a field trips. **The vehicle has to be booked at least a day in advance. For bookings, call 9444398182.**



### Help at the polling station

If you know someone who would need a wheelchair or a sign language interpreter at the polling booth then ask them to download the Election Commission of India's Saksham App. This tool for persons with disabilities allows them to participate in the electoral process with some degree of ease. It offers them a number of features including how to find their polling station.

The mobile application is currently making sure there is wheelchair support at the polling booth, Indian Sign Language Interpreter and help to deal

with other concerns. The App requires one to place a request in advance so that a volunteer can be arranged on polling day.



A sign language interpreter working with the team says they have close to 15 interpreters and the requests placed on the App are by individuals as well as associations working for PwDs.

In the 2024 Lok Sabha Elections, most polling stations only had a booth where one could reach out for any assistance. A sign language interpreter says, "Through a video call made from the stall, we were assisting the deaf and the mute. This time, the plan is to have both."

### Special buses

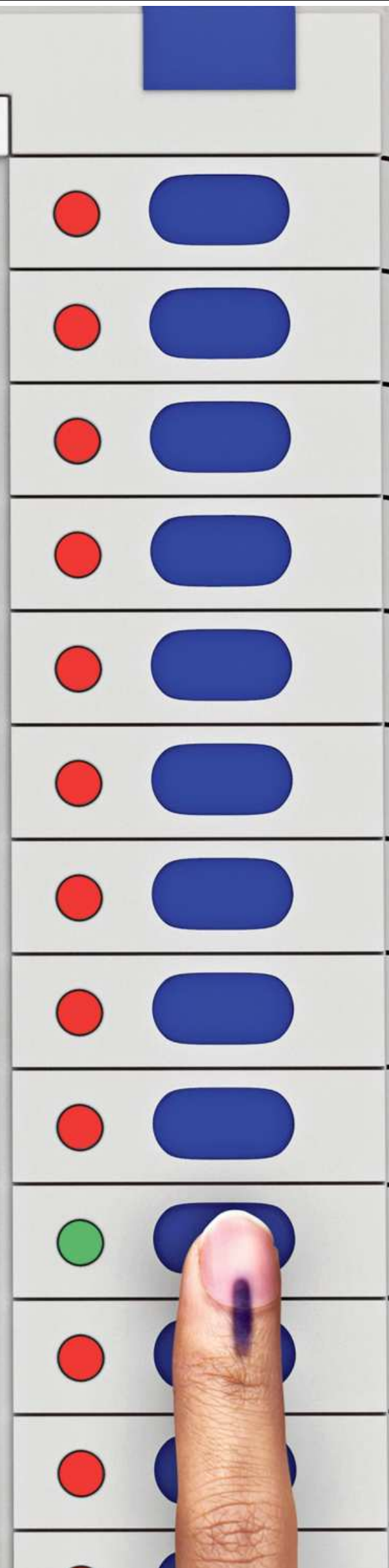
Tamil Nadu State Transport Corporation will ply special long-distance buses from April 21 to 23 to enable people to get their polling booth without much difficulty.

From Kalaignar Centenary Bus Terminus (KCBT) in Kilambak-

kam, buses will operate to Pudukcherry, Cuddalore, Chidambaram, Trichy, Madurai, Tuticorin and Coimbatore. At Koyambedu, find buses going to East Coast Road, Vellore, Thiruttani and Bengaluru. From Madhavaram New Bus Stand, there are buses to Andhra Pradesh via Ponneri,

Gummidipoondi, and to Trichy, Salem, Kumbakonam, and Thiruvannamalai. The public can book tickets online through [www.tnsrc.in](http://www.tnsrc.in) and on the official Tamil Nadu State Transport Corporation app.

**To learn more about bus routes, call 94450 14436.**







M. Dhulath Sah leading a yoga session at the park.

## A model volunteer at May Day Park

A Chintadripet resident takes enormous efforts to create a sense of community at this famous green space

R. RAGU

**M**. Dhulath Sah is an unpaid staffer at May Day Park in Chintadripet, volunteering to enhance the park-going experience for visitors.

He conducts yoga classes for anyone who cares to enrol for it, trains children in badminton, all of them done *pro bono*.

On special occasions, notable among them being Independence Day, Pongal and Republic Day, he decorates the park, the effort fuelled by money volunteered by visitors.

From time to time, he also conducts sports and cultural events for children, which culminate in a prize-giving ceremony.

A resident of Ayya Street, 59-

year-old Dhulath was running a two-wheeler spare parts shop, which he had shut down permanently due to the pandemic.

His home is being run by the salary brought home by his elder son, 24-year-old Rahul Sah who pursues CA and works at a consultancy firm in his spare time. His other son, Prasanth Sah is studying BPharm.

## Podiatrist honoured



The Rotary Club of Madras Mid Town - Rotary International District 3233 has conferred the Vocational Excellence Award upon Dr. T. V. Raja. According to a press release, he is a distinguished orthopaedic foot and ankle surgeon and is known for his dedicated service in the field of podiatry. He is a resident of T.Nagar.

## Book for senior citizens released

**A** special gathering titled "Story of a Banyan Tree" was held on April 11 at the National Centre of Ageing (NCA) in Guindy.

V. S. Natarajan, a renowned geriatric physician and educationist, spoke about the evolution of geriatric medicine in India, tracing its beginning and steady growth year after year.

The event was presided over by S. Deepa, director of NCA. V. Kanasabai, former head of the department at Madras Medical College and Research Institute, spoke in detail about how to care for the elderly and the importance of it. A Tamil book in the title of *Keezhe*

*Vizhamal Nalamaai Vazhuvom* was also launched for senior citizens, with around 500 copies of the book donated to the NCA.

In his address, Dr. Natarajan shared that his journey in geriatric care began 46 years ago. He also expressed gratitude to Bangaru Adigalar, and professor Annamalai who guided him through this division of medicine. Referring to the theme, he described the banyan tree's shade as a metaphor for the NCA which has been providing care and support to countless elderly individuals across the country. Many senior citizens and medical professionals across the city attended the event.

## Three-day workshop on baking

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu is conducting a baking workshop from April 28 to 30. According to a press release, the session will focus on making cookies, biscuits, chocolates, and cakes from millets.

The centre is also conducting another training programme on making skincare products from April 28 to 30. The session will focus on making soaps and shampoos from bio-enzymes, adds the release.

Also, a beautician course will be held from April 21 to 22. Participants will be taught sari draping, hairstyling, and a few



A REPRESENTATIONAL PHOTO ONLY

more.

All the sessions will be held at the institute's premises at EDII Office Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 8668102600 / 87544 95254

## Community dogs vaccinated



Close to 30 community dogs in T.Nagar were administered anti rabies vaccination. According to a press release, this exercise was carried out by Bhuvana and K. RajaRaman.

The exercise was conducted with the approval of Dr. Kamal Husain, Chief Veterinary Officer, Greater Chennai Corporation.



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Chennai resident Visalakshi Jambunathan suffered a stroke seven years ago. Despite that, she headed to the polling booth in previous elections. This time around, she decided to make it easy for herself by opting for home voting; and she found the process to be easier than she expected it to be

LIFFY THOMAS

**T**hey want to fulfill their duty. And they want to fulfill it from the safety of their home due to their fragile health and advanced age.

Voting for senior citizens above 85 years and for voters with disabilities that have expressed preference to vote from home commenced in all 16 Assembly constituencies in Chennai on April 16.

A team of six comprising a micro observer, two polling officials, a police officer, a videographer and a driver landed at 74-year-old Visalakshi Jambunathan's house at Kalukaran Street in Mylapore around 11 a.m. after a word from the Booth Level Officer.

While the former chemistry teacher from Vidya Mandir Senior Secondary School in Mylapore is

# Easy does it; just vote from home



A senior citizen from Royapuram Assembly constituency shows her inked finger and (below) V. Santhanam with polling officials.

PHOTOS: B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

our finger inked after voting, but here they took my signature as proof that I have voted and have scratched my name from the list," says Visalakshi.

Seven years ago, following a stroke, the teacher suffered disability in her left leg and since then she uses splint to walk.

"My handicap has not limited me where my routine is concerned. I still go about doing all my work. As this option was available, I thought, 'Why not use it?'. The officials had come home a month ago

happy to be the first in her family and friends circles to have voted from home, she was missing something. "We are so used to getting

## Home voters in each constituency

Velachery

**1,064**

Thiyagarayanagar

**1,005**

Kolathur

**906**

Anna Nagar

**855**

Virugambakkam

**745**

Mylapore

**725**

Thousand Lights

**657**

Saidapet

**531**

Perambur

**459**

Villivakkam

**430**

Egmore

**344**

Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni

**327**

*Figures of persons who will be voting under the category of senior citizens, absentee voters and persons with disabilities*

to verify the details that I had presented through Form 12D," says the former school teacher who has never missed voting.

Eight-eight-year-old V. Santhanam is always on the go, taking up civic issues with elected representatives and officials.

"I can easily walk down to the booth but I wanted to experience the system and I have to commend how the Election Commission has organised this," says the social activist from Chromepet.

He is of the opinion that many senior citizens are not aware of the "vote from home" option and more awareness about it needs to be created.

## Old age homes

At Vishranthi Old Age Home in Palavakkam, five residents availed this option. All of them are bed-ridden but had expressed interest in voting, so the management made all the necessary arrangements. At least six others will be going to the polling booths to cast their vote.

At Anandhanam Old Age Home in Ambattur, one of the first things the management wants the residents to do is update the address on their Aadhar card and other documents. This is helpful to avail various benefits offered by the government to senior citizens, and comes handy during election time. This time, 20 people exercised their vote.

According to a report in *The Hindu*, with 106 requests, Kolathur has the highest number of persons with disabilities who have availed themselves of the home voting facility in Chennai. Royapuram has the lowest, with just 14 home voters.

## SRMIST secures ANRF-PM Early Career Research Grant

SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST) has secured ten grants under the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF)-Prime Minister Early Career Research Grant Scheme with a cumulative funding of around ₹ 6.03 crore.

Across disciplines such as chemistry, nanotechnology, physics, medical research, and genetic engineering, these projects focus on emerging areas, including advanced materials, AI-driven re-

search, healthcare innovation, and sustainable technologies, a press release stated.

At a Research Day event on Friday, Shivkumar Kalyanaraman, CEO, ANRF, highlighted opportunities through ANRF, including large-scale funding and industry-linked initiatives, and encouraged institutions to focus on high-quality research that translates into societal and economic value.

P. Sathyanarayanan, Pro-Chancellor (Academics), SRMIST, C. Muthamizhchelvan, Vice Chancellor, SRMIST, and B. Venkatachalapathy, Research Professor, SRMIST, were among those present.

## Summer camp by ISKCON

ISKCON Chennai is conducting summer camp, both online and offline at multiple locations for children and teens on the theme 'Divine Questions and Divine Answers'.

The two-week camp will be conducted in April and May, with English or Tamil as medium of instruction. Children (6 to 12 years) will get to learn with stories, quizzes, shlokas, bhajans, fireless cooking, art and craft while the teens would have theme-based stories, debates, discussions and JAM sessions. Duration of each class is 1.5 - 2 hours. One must register with a minimal fee. Course materials such as videos, PDF, PPT will be shared to participants through WhatsApp. Participants will receive a certificate on completion of the course. For details, call 8072599295.

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